



Comparatives and Superlatives Podcast

Gate 4 – Timetables

Welcome to Gate 4

"The metro is faster" is grammatically perfect, but practically **completely empty**.

Is it faster by **1 minute**, or by an hour?

We must learn to fill this **hidden space**.



The B2 to C1 Upgrade

You can upgrade your sentences from a **B2 level to a C1 level**.

You do this by filling a **hidden space** in front of every comparative adjective.

C1

ถ.ว.

Revealing the Hidden Space

- 1 A comparative is a word comparing two things, like "**faster**" or "**cheaper**".
- 2 The hidden space right in front of it is the **differential slot**.
- 3 It is waiting for you to tell us the **exact size** of the difference.

faster

Four Distinct Ways

There are **four distinct ways** to fill the differential slot.

The absolute rule: the amount **always goes directly before** the adjective.



Way 1: Exact Numbers

You can drop in an **exact measurement**.

10 minutes	faster
400 baht	cheaper
three kilograms	lighter



A Common Error

You cannot say
~~"faster 10 minutes".~~

This is a really **common mistake**.

The amount must sit in the slot
before the comparative word.

~~faster 10 minutes~~

Ways 2 & 3: Vague Degrees

If you don't have exact numbers, use a **vague degree**.

Large degree:

- **much**
- **significantly**

Small degree:

- **marginally**
- **slightly**



A young girl with dark hair tied in a ponytail with a white bow, wearing a white school uniform shirt with a blue logo on the left chest. She is making a hand gesture with both hands, forming a rectangular shape with her fingers. The background is a blurred classroom setting.

Way 4: Zero

You can even use **zero** to fill the slot.

Example: “**no** faster than the bus”.

It perfectly defines the gap as non-existent.

⊗ ERROR

((very faster))

The Logic of "Very"

Block 1 The Error Diagnosis

Students constantly say things like
~~"very faster"~~ or ~~"very more crowded"~~.

Block 2 The Synthesis Rule

This does not work, and it is based on
pure logic, not a random rule.



Positions vs. Gaps

Point 1.

“Very” intensifies a position on a scale
 (“very fast” describes the runner).

Point 2.

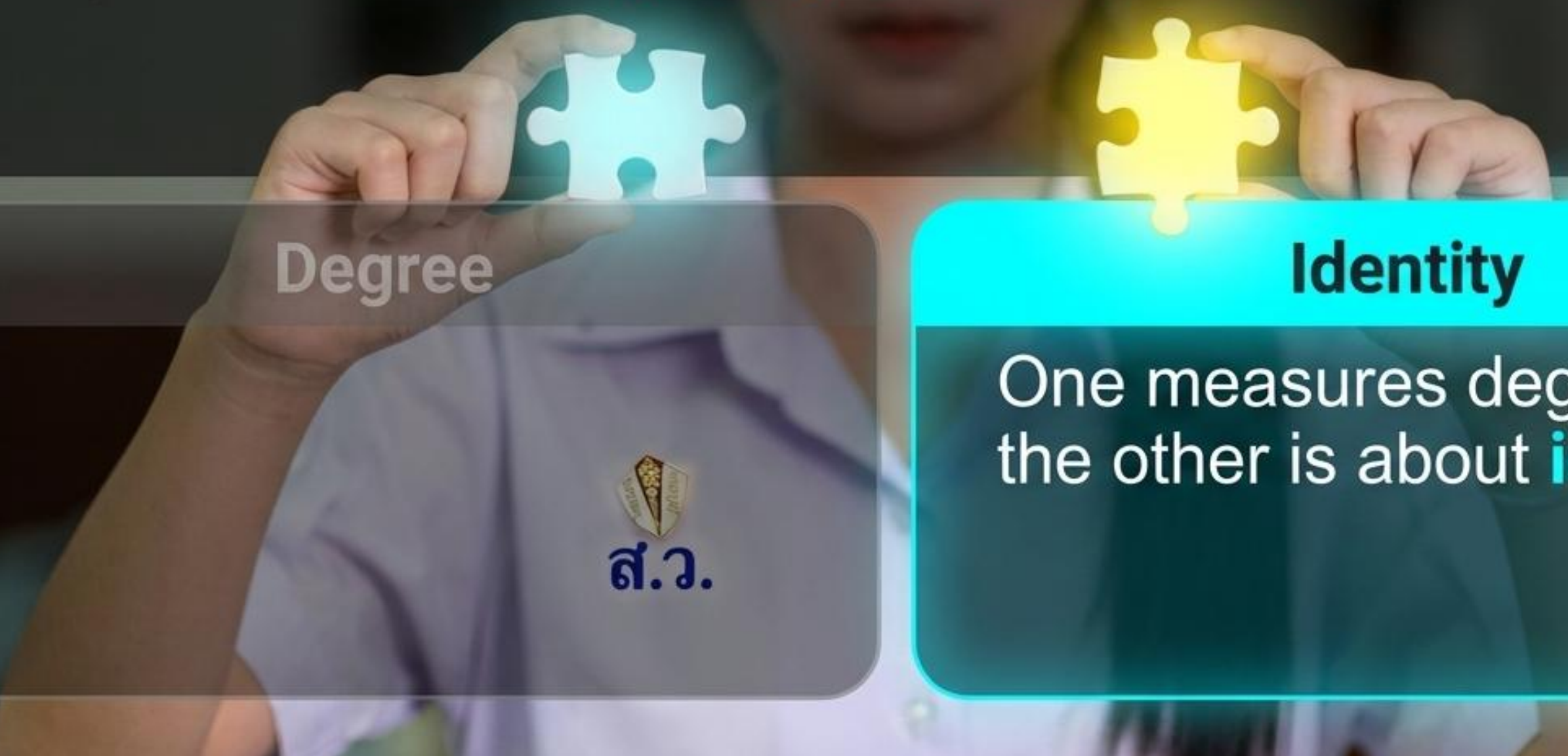
Comparatives name a **difference** or
gap between two positions.

Point 3.

You can **measure a gap**,
but you **cannot intensify a gap**.

Very with Superlatives

We definitely say “**the very fastest** service”.
English has **two completely different words** spelled v-e-r-y.



Degree

ส.ว.

Identity

One measures degree;
the other is about **identity**.

Precisely That One

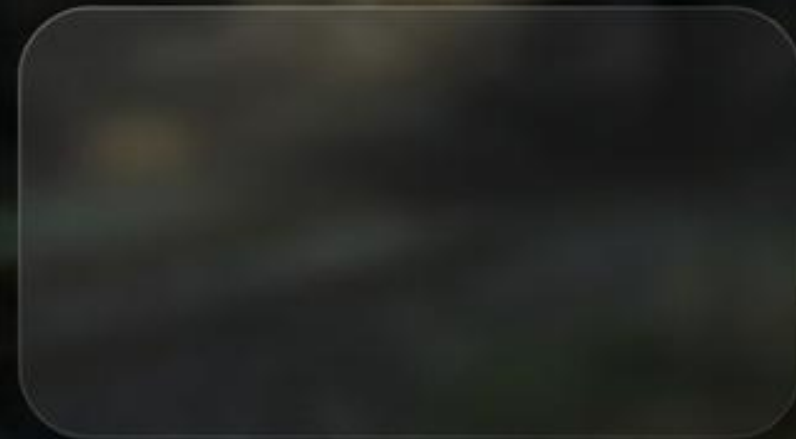
When used with a superlative, “very” means **precisely that one** and no other.



Superlatives like “fastest” talk about **unique things**.



Because they are unique, they take **identity words**.



Phrases for Your Exam

“**by far** the busiest station”

“**easily** the least reliable airline”

“**comfortably** the cheapest option”



Facts vs. Feelings

Changing one word in the differential slot changes the **whole attitude** of the sentence.

Neutral	Emotional
“The new timetable is not faster” (Neutral dry fact)	“The new timetable is no faster” (Implies disappointment)



Conveying Disappointment

Using “**no faster**” tells the listener a story.

It signals that somebody **expected an improvement** and didn't get it.

Contradictions for Emphasis

"**No fewer than** 300 passengers
were stranded."

It sounds like a reduction, but the
meaning is **pure emphasis**.

It means that is a **huge amount** of people.

The 5 Baht Difference

False

If a train is 45 baht and a bus is 40 baht, writing “**much more expensive**” is false. The gap is only 5 baht.

Factual

You must say “**marginally more expensive**” to avoid a factual error.



C1 Level Sentences

Weak: “Rail travel got **better**.”

Better: “Rail use rose **considerably** while car use declined.”

Strongest: “Rail journeys rose **41%** while car journeys **fell 6%.**”

Hard Facts

- ➔ Utilize the differential slot perfectly to achieve **C1 proficiency**.
- ➔ Replace empty adjectives with **concrete data**.
- ➔ Turn a vague opinion into a **hard fact**.



Two Questions to Ask

Every time you write a comparative, do not leave the slot empty. Ask yourself two questions:

Compared to what?
And by how much?

